

30-minute cheesy broccoli pesto pasta with lemon pepper chicken

BY CAROLINE CHAMBERS

Serves 4-6

Cook time: 30 minutes

Tools:

- Large pot
- If you have one, a steamer basket or metal colander that fits inside your large pot OR a slotted spoon
- [Microplane](#)
- Large skillet ([cast-iron](#) or [non-stick](#))
- [Meat thermometer](#)
- [Tongs](#)
- Box grater
- [Blender](#) (a food processor would also work)
- 2 cups of broccoli florets (or one 10-ounce bag steam-in-bag broccoli — see the “quick note” section above the recipe for more on this)
- 1 pound of boneless skinless chicken thighs
- EVOO
- 2 lemons (ideally organic since we’re zesting them)
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- 1 cup of full-fat cottage cheese
- 1/2 cup of grated Parm (Parmigiano Reggiano if you can find it)
- 2 garlic cloves, peeled
- 1 cup packed basil leaves
- 1 cup packed spinach leaves
- 1/2 cup milk of choice

Ingredients:

- 1 pound of pasta of your choice (I chose Cavatappi)

Bring a large pot of salted water to a boil and cook **1 pound of pasta of your choice** about 1 minute less than package instructions (we will cook the pasta more in the sauce). Before you drain the pasta, **RESERVE ABOUT 1 CUP OF PASTA COOKING WATER (bolding this so you don’t forget!!!)**. Drain the noodles, return the cooked pasta to the pot, and set aside.

Meanwhile, steam **2 cups of broccoli florets** until bright green and crisp tender, about 5 minutes.

You can do this several ways: If you have a steamer basket or metal colander that fits in your large pot, steam the broccoli above the boiling noodles for the last 5 minutes of cooking. To do so, set the basket/colander in the pot, add the broccoli, and put a lid on top of the pot. If you don’t have a steamer insert or colander that works, boil the broccoli after the noodles are done in the same water — use a slotted spoon to remove the noodles then add the broccoli and cook for 4 to 5 minutes. If you don’t want to do either, buy steam-in-bag broccoli florets and microwave them while the noodles are boiling!

While the noodles boil and the broccoli steams, pat **1 pound of boneless skinless chicken thighs** dry, drizzle them generously all over with **EVOO** and season both sides with **a big pinch of salt and lots of pepper**. No need to measure the pepper, just sprinkle/grind it on liberally. Use a microplane to grate **the zest of 1 lemon** evenly over the chicken thighs.

Heat a large cast-iron (or non-stick) skillet over medium-high heat (no, you don’t need to add oil to the pan!), and when almost smoking, add your seasoned chicken thighs and cook for 4 minutes. Peek at the bottom of the chicken — if it’s golden brown, flip it using tongs or a spatula. If not, let it cook for 1 more

minute then flip it. Cook for another 4 or 5 minutes, until the other side is also golden brown and the chicken is cooked through (use a meat thermometer to double check temperature, if you have one — it's done at 165°F). Set the cooked chicken aside. Using the lemon you zested, squeeze **lemon juice** over the chicken then let it rest while you prepare the pasta sauce.

To a blender, add **the steamed broccoli, 1 cup of full-fat cottage cheese, 1/2 cup of grated Parm, 2 peeled garlic cloves, 1 cup packed basil leaves, 1 cup packed spinach leaves, 1/2 cup milk of choice, a large pinch of salt, and the zest and juice of the second lemon**. Blend until smooth. I like a smooth alfredo-y consistency for this sauce! If it's too thick, add a little more milk.

Returning back to your pasta pot, turn the heat back on to medium. Add your broccoli pesto to the pasta, along with **1/4 cup of pasta water**. Stir and toss to coat your pasta in the sauce, until warm and glossy, about 2 minutes. Add more pasta water if you feel like the sauce needs to loosen up a bit. Taste it! Does it need more salt, pepper, or lemon juice? Add it until it's perfectly seasoned.

Serve your pasta with sliced pieces of chicken on top, freshly grated Parm, and a few basil leaves. For extra deliciousness, also garnish with a drizzle of EVOO, a squeeze of lemon, and some flaky salt.
ENJOY!